Bench exercise: read your edge tools

Japanese Joinery by Hand · Episode 4 · Part 2. Learn what your chisel, hammer and plane are telling you, before any cutting. The exercise works with Japanese tools (*nomi* 鑿, *gennō* 玄能, *kanna* 鉋) or Western ones. About 40 minutes.

Safety. Edges are sharp: never point a chisel's edge at yourself or anyone else, and lay tools down with the edge away from you. Sharp-tool technique, including sharpening, is best learned from a teacher, at a bench, in person.

1 · Read a chisel

1. Look at the bevel side, near the edge, under a good light. On a laminated Japanese chisel you may be able to see where the hard steel meets the softer iron. Where is the steel: on the flat back, or on the bevel side?
2. Look at the back. Is there a shallow hollow (*urasuki* 裏スキ)? It is there to make the back easier to flatten.
3. Struck or pushed? A hoop (*katsura*) on the handle end means the chisel is struck.

2 · The two faces of a gennō

1. On scrap softwood, drive two nails nearly home with the flat face.
2. Give the last blows to one nail with the flat face, and to the other with the slightly domed face (*kigoroshi-men* 木殺し面).
3. **Check:** compare the surface around each nail head. Which shows a hammer mark?

3 · Set a plane blade by tapping

1. Sight down the sole toward a light, with the plane upside down. Can you see the edge?
2. To set it deeper, give the blade's head a light tap with the hammer. To draw it back, tap the corners of the block's head end.
3. Make one tap at a time, and look again after each tap. Aim for a hair-thin, even projection across the width.
4. **Check:** take a shaving on a scrap of softwood. Is it even in thickness across its width? If not, which side is the blade further out on?

What you should have

- A note of where your chisel's steel is, and whether it has a back hollow.
- Two nails, one finished with each face, and an answer about marks.
- One even shaving.

These steps follow the national skills-test manual's description of blade setting (Japan's MHLW). With a Western plane, use its adjuster instead of taps.